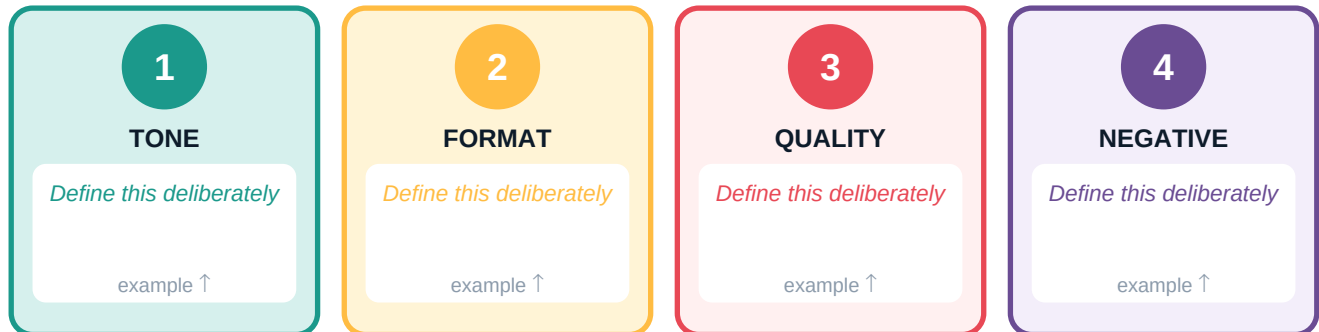


CHAPTER 8

Examples Change Everything



SHOWING VERSUS TELLING There are two ways to specify what you want from AI. You can describe it, or you can demonstrate it.

Describing works for many things. But when tone, format, or style is what you care about, demonstrating is almost always more effective.

This is because language about language is inherently imprecise. "Warm but professional" means something different to you than it does to AI. "Clear and engaging" is interpreted through thousands of examples in AI's training data, most of which are not exactly what you meant. The gap between your description and AI's interpretation is where most style failures live.

An example collapses that gap. Instead of asking AI to match your description of a style, you are showing it the style and asking it to match that.

TYPES OF EXAMPLES Examples can take several forms:

TONE EXAMPLES A piece of your own writing, or a piece of writing in the voice you want. "Write in the same tone as this email I wrote last year" or "match the style of this example I'm pasting in."

FORMAT EXAMPLES A previous document in the format you need. "Use the same structure as this report section." "Produce output that looks like this."

QUALITY STANDARD EXAMPLES A high-quality output you want to match or improve on. "This is an example of the level of specificity I want."

NEGATIVE EXAMPLES Something you don't want. "Do not write like this" is sometimes as effective as "write like this."

WHY IT WORKS PROVIDING EXAMPLES IS WHAT AI RESEARCHERS CALL "FEW-SHOT PROMPTING", GIVING AI A SMALL NUMBER

similar vocabulary choices, similar sentence length, similar structural decisions. Your description of "professional" is abstract; an example of it is concrete.

THE BEFORE -> BETTER -> BEST: EXAMPLES The scenario: Margaret wants a weekly AI-generated summary of news relevant to her industry (sustainable packaging) to send to her team. She wants it to sound as if she wrote it, not AI.

BEFORE

"Write a summary of this week's sustainability news for my team."

Output: A formal, comprehensive news summary. Heavy paragraphs. AI-standard prose. Margaret would have to rewrite it entirely before it sounds like her.

BETTER

"Write a summary of this week's sustainability packaging news for my team. Tone: conversational, direct, not overly formal."

Chapter 8 - Examples Change Everything

Output: Less formal, but still not quite right. "Conversational" is interpreted differently by different people, and AI doesn't know what Margaret sounds like.

BEST

"I write a weekly news summary for my team of 8. Here is an example of one from three months ago that captured the tone exactly right:



[EXAMPLE SUMMARY]

'Three things from this week:

- The EU is tightening its position on recycled content claims, this matters for our German clients more than anywhere else. Worth watching.
- Paperboard prices stabilised in October after six months of increases. Our procurement team will already know this, but the sector analysis I've linked to is good background.

- Maersk announced a new bio-methanol shipping route.
- Too early to know if this is real progress or PR. I'll share
- more when I know more.'

Write this week's summary in the same format and voice. Source material I'm attaching covers: [pasted or uploaded articles]. Keep it to three items unless something genuinely warrants a fourth."

Output: A summary that reads like it could have been written by Margaret, same three-item structure, same direct tone, same characteristic qualification ("too early to know"). She edits two words and sends it.



WHAT CHANGED?



PART II - BUILD BETTER INTERACTIONS



WHAT WAS ADDED WHY IT MATTERED

Example of actual past output Gave AI a concrete target instead of abstract description

Format from example Three numbered items, short, no preamble

Voice characteristics from Opinionated, direct, honest about uncertainty example

Source material provided Grounded in real content rather than general knowledge

Constraint on length Prevented overgeneration

USING YOUR OWN WRITING AS AN EXAMPLE One of the most practical applications of example-giving is using your own previous writing to teach AI your voice. This is particularly useful for:

Regular communications: weekly updates, team emails, client newsletters Documents with a house style: reports, proposals in a format you've established Personal correspondence: emails where you want AI to draft and you want it to sound like you

The method: provide two or three examples of your writing in the relevant genre, and ask AI to match the style. Longer examples give AI more to work from. If you have a document that perfectly captures your voice or style, use that as the primary reference.

PRO TIP IF YOU SAVE A "STYLE REFERENCE" DOCUMENT IN YOUR AI WORKSPACE (CHAPTER 11), YOU DON'T NEED TO PASTE

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WHEN NOT TO USE EXAMPLES Examples constrain AI toward the example. This is usually what you want, but not always.

If you want AI to be creative, novel, or to produce something better than your existing examples, providing examples can limit the output. In those cases, describe the qualities you want and explicitly say: "Feel free to go beyond this starting point."

Similarly: if the examples you have are not actually that good, AI may faithfully replicate their weaknesses. Use examples you would genuinely like to match.

WATCH OUT EXAMPLES ARE MOST EFFECTIVE FOR STYLE AND FORMAT. THEY ARE LESS EFFECTIVE FOR ACCURACY. PROVIDE



PART II - BUILD BETTER INTERACTIONS